

SHOWING RATHER THAN TELLING

Letting the reader work it out for themselves



1 What is it?

Showing Rather Than Telling

"Show, don't tell" means revealing information through **action, dialogue and detail** rather than stating it directly — letting the reader work it out for themselves.

telling: "she was sad" → showing: her actions prove it

2 See it in action

Telling

She was nervous. Flat, direct — the reader is simply informed.

Showing

Her fingers wouldn't stop tapping the desk. The reader infers the nervousness.

Telling

He was rich.

Showing

He left a fifty on the table without checking the bill.



You got this!

When you spot a physical detail (shaking hands, avoiding eye contact) ask what **emotion or fact** it's quietly proving without saying it outright.

FUN FACT

"Show, don't tell" is one of the most repeated pieces of writing advice in history, but professional writers still use "telling" deliberately for pace — showing is for the moments that matter most.

3 Why writers use it

Showing Rather Than Telling help writers: make the reader an active participant rather than a passive receiver of facts, create more believable and immersive writing, and trust the reader's intelligence to draw their own conclusions.

Showing isn't about using more words — it's about choosing ONE specific, concrete detail that implies a feeling or fact, rather than simply stating it.

4 Where you'll spot it

Literary fiction

Skilled writers rarely name an emotion directly — they let physical detail and action reveal it instead.

Film & TV

A director can't use narration to say "he was guilty" — the whole medium depends on showing through action and expression.



Watch out!

Showing doesn't mean never stating a fact directly — sometimes telling is the right, efficient choice. The skill is knowing WHEN a moment deserves showing for maximum impact.



Good spot!

Try replacing a "telling" sentence in your own writing with one specific action or detail instead — "he was angry" might become "he slammed the door so hard the frame rattled."

5 Quick recap

Reveals feeling through
action/detail

Rather than stating it
directly

Lets the reader work it
out



Keep going!

Pick an emotion (jealousy, guilt, excitement) and write one sentence that shows it through action alone, with no emotion-word used at all.